A tale of two genitives

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Introduction.[1] In this paper, I explore the distribution of two phonologically identical morphemes of Iron Ossetic (< Iranian < Indo-European), which has not been considered in the previous literature. One is a true case morpheme, exponing the genitive case, while another is an adjectivizer morpheme. I show that these two affixes attach to constituents of different structural sizes.

Ossetic nominal & adjectival morphology. The Ossetic nominal inflection is agglutinative: case and number are always exponed separately. The genitive, exponed as /ə/, standardly arises in possessive constructions on possessors (1a) and in complements of postpositions (1b).

(1) a. *jæ= quš-t-**ə** kæræ-ttæ*
poss.3sg=ear-pl-gen tip-pl
'the tips's of his ears' (Abaev 1964: 93)

b. *jæ= mad-**ə** sur*
poss.3sg=mother-gen besides
'besides one's mother' (Abaev 1964: 18)

The categorial distintinction between nouns and adjectives is not clear-cut due to cases of conversion (2). Still, certain nouns attach overt adjectivizing markers, such as *-džən* (3). Examples (2)–(5) come from an Ossetic-Russian dictionary by Guriev & Gutieva (2019).

(2) a. ***žærond**-əl ma= ba-xud*
old-super neg=pv-laugh.imp
'don't laugh at an old [person]'

b. ***žærond** uš*
old woman
'an old woman'

(3) *av-**džən** dzauma*
glass-adj crockery
'glassware'

However, the adjectives listed for certain nouns are conspicuously similar to their genitive forms:

(4) ***lævar-ə** nom-æn*
gift-gen name-dat
'as a gift (in the name of a gift)'

(5) ***lævar-ə** fəšt*
gift-adj writing
'(dedication) inscription'

As I show below, this similarity is superficial, the /ə/ in (1) & (5) being distinct morphosyntactic entities.

Diagnosing structural size. "Genitive adjectives" as in (5) display a number of properties which consistently align them with adjectives rather than true genitives. For example, the source noun cannot receive number marking (6; the [j] before /ə/ is due to phonological epenthesis). Importantly, this cannot be attributed to potential contextual licensing on the use of the singular form instead of the plural: if the same source noun is construed as an oblique object of the predicate, plural marking is required (7).

(6) *fætk^{w}ə-jə* / **fætk^{w}ə-t-ə varennæ*
apple-gen/adj apple-pl-gen/adj jam
š-kod-ton
pv-do-pst.1pl
'I made apple jam.'

(7) *š-kod-ton varennæ fætk^{w}ə-*(t)-æj*
pv-do-pst.1pl jam apple-pl-abl
'I made jam out of apples.'

The source noun generally cannot be modifed by another adjective (8), suggesting the marker /ə/ here attaches to a constituent of a smaller size.

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(8) *ʔšərx fætkʷə-jə varennæ š-kod-ton*
red apple-GEN/ADJ jam PV-do-PST.1PL
Intended: 'I made red apple jam.'

If the source noun has a dedicated adjectivizer, such as *-džən* for *bal-džən* <cherry-ADJ>, *-ə* becomes unavailable, meaning this marker participates in blocking relationships with other adjectivizers.

(9) **bal-ə* / *bal-džən varennæ š-kod-ton*
cherry-GEN/ADJ cherry-ADJ jam PV-do-PST.1SG
'I made cherry jam.'

Ossetic allows suspended affixation of case markers, but not of derivational affixes (Belyaev 2014). The *ə*-adjectivizer cannot be suspended, at least for some speakers (10), suggestive of its derivational nature.

(10) *mæ= fəd neft-*(ə) æmæ qæd-ə institut axʷər kod-ta*
POSS.1SG=father oil-GEN/ADJ and forest-GEN/ADJ institute study do-PST.1SG
'My father studied at the oil and forestry insistute.'

Another piece of evidence comes from the comitative preposition *æd*. Erschler (2019) shows that this preposition cannot take noun phrases with genitive possessors as complements (11). However, there are examples where the *æd*-complement contains a *-ə*-marked noun. In such cases, the source noun receives a non-referential, kind-like interpretation (12).

(11) **æd šošlan-ə durən ærba-səd-tæn*
with Soslan-GEN jug PV-go-PST.1SG
Intended: 'I arrived with Soslan's jug / a jug of Soslan.' (Erschler 2019)

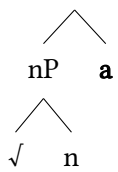
(12) *æd kommuništ-ə mi-tæ æmæ sard*
with communist-GEN/ADJ deed-PL and live
'{His grandfather was a true communist: with a member's card, with a communist's face, } a communist's deeds and live.' (Ossetic National Corpus)

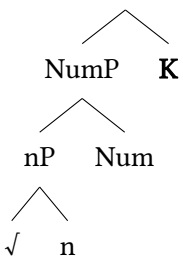
Erschler (2019) posits that *æd* takes NumP, at most, as its complement. Genitive possessors are located higher, in Spec,DP. Thus, *kommuništ-ə* in (12) could be construed as an *-ə*-derived adjective, located lower in the structure, with *-ə* as the adjectivizing head *a*. This is inline with the diagnostics laid out above.

Finally, *-ə-* can appear in iterative structures with other adjectivizers in the context of head ellipsis:

(13) ***fætkʷə-jə-on*** *=ta š-twag i*
apple-ADJ_1-ADJ_2=CT PV-sour AUX
'{In the summer I made two cans of jam: a cherry one and an apple one. In the winter I started eating the cherry jam,} but **the apple one** got sour {an I had to throw it away.}'

To conclude, the data laid out above suggests the existence of two morphemes with distinct structural positions: a low adjectivizing head *a* (14) and a high case affix in K (15).

(14)


(15)


A diachronic parallel. Interestingly, Miller (1903) previously connected the Ossetic genitive marker to the Iranian suffixes *-iya, -ia, -ya*, which were used to form relational adjectives. Given the representations of the two suffixes in (14)–(15) and the fact that the adjectivizer is located significantly lower in the

structure than the genitive marker, this is in line with more modern ideas of grammaticalization taking place "upwards in the tree", cf. Roberts & Roussou (2003: 36) and Roberts (2010: 53).

Gloss list. 1, 3 — 1st, 3rd person, ABL — ablative, ADJ — adjectivizer, AUX — auxiliary verb, CT — contrastive topic, DAT — dative, GEN — genitive, GEN/ADJ — -ə-marker, IMP — imperative, NEG — negation PL — plural, POSS — possessive, PST — past tense, PV — preverb, SG — singular, SUPER — superlative

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